

Good and bad user interfaces

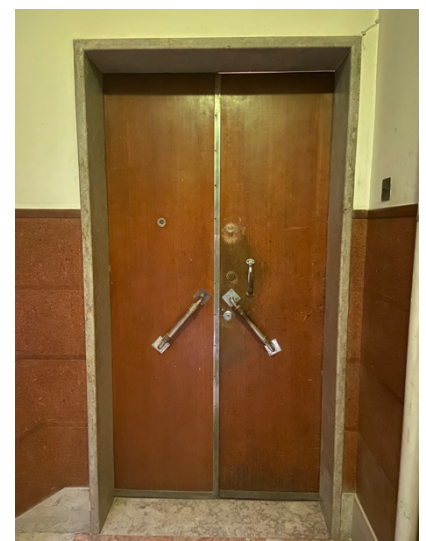
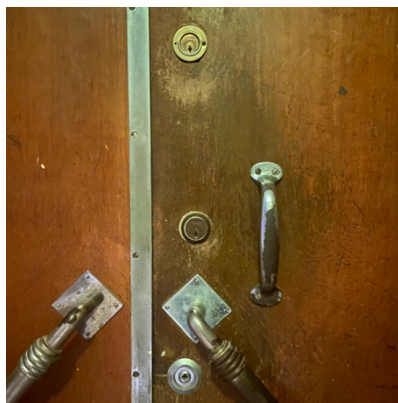
Example of a bad user interface: Locks on my Apartment Door

The objective of a lock on an apartment door is to be unlocked with the correct key from the outside, or unlocked without a key from the inside, and then opened. This process is supposed to be easy and fast, since it is performed multiple times a day.

The problem with this specific door is the existence of three locks, out of which only one is the correct one which will open the door. Consequently, new users must use a trial-and-error strategy, with only a 33% chance of picking the right lock on the first try, making it confusing and time-consuming to unlock the door. This issue arises both when entering (using a key) and leaving (using the metal clicker) the apartment. A further minor bad aspect is the way the door handles are mounted from the outside. Even though the left part of the door is never opened, it has a handle on it, prompting users to try to push it, providing even more confusion.

The three locks were probably mounted one after the other due to malfunction of the previous one(s), so this user interface was most likely created by accident. This means that as opposed to bad engineering, it is simply a lack of intentionality that led to the described problematic user experience.

To correct this problem, one could simply dismount the two unused locks, leaving only one clear choice for the correct lock, no trial-and-error needed. Additionally, the handle on the left part of the door could be taken off as well.



Example of a good user interface: Google Search Engine Homepage

The main objective of a search engine is to let users easily and quickly look up things.

The Google search engine does a great job at guiding users to fulfill exactly that objective. The search bar is very prominent in the middle of the page, larger than other buttons or links. Additionally, the slight shadow border makes it pop out from the rest of the page. Even further, most of the rest of the page is left blank. These aspects combined make it the first thing users look at, allowing them to instantly find the correct place to enter their search query. Also, the cursor is by default already inside the search bar, so users can instantly start typing without having to click anywhere. Other, more seldomly used functions like the settings are unobtrusively located in the top right corner.

